that the first prime ministerial visit took two full decades after independence, that of Indira Gandhi in 1968.

In many ways, Australia tended to be the most distant of the Anglosphere partners. It displayed the attitude of the US to issues east of India and the approach of the UK to concerns on the west. On the other hand, the Commonwealth framework ensured that there were steady exchanges in a large number of domains, including defence, commerce, training and education. What was a substantial but not high-profile relationship also took a marked dip in 1998. Australia took the lead in calling for a special session of the Conference on Disarmament and co-sponsored a resolution in the United Nations General Assembly (UNGA) condemning India's nuclear tests. More significantly, it suspended defence cooperation and froze official contacts. The story was, in many ways, very similar to that of Japan.

It took a year for the two sides to step back from the confrontational posture. The visit of Deputy PM Tim Fisher in 1999 could be credited as the beginning of the thaw. In a sense, Australia was ahead of Japan in repairing its ties, evidenced in the visits of Foreign Minister Alexander Downer and PM John Howard in March and July 2000 respectively. The return to normalcy progressed steadily and was accelerated somewhat by the tail winds of the 2005 nuclear deal. But the reality nevertheless was that neither nation devoted the political attention to the other which was required to take ties to a higher level.

Certainly, on the Indian side, there was a continued perception that Australia had neither de-hyphenated its subcontinental relationships nor emerged from a general disinterest about the region. not matched the US or even Japan in. So, for almost a decade more, the progress of ties was left largely to civil society and market forces. It took the two-way visits of PMs Tony Abbott and Narendra Modi in 2014 to open the gates for cooperation that was so long delayed.

That ties developed so rapidly once political leadership came into play only underlines the extent of the structural convergence. The ambitions that guide this exercise are best explained by *An India Economic Strategy to 2035 Report* released by the Australian side and the *Australia Economic Strategy* issued by India. A trade of $20 billion plus and investments around $25 billion stand to benefit with a free trade arrangement whose initial phase has commenced. Australia is a major educational destination for